
Where the Movement Penalty Goes: a Correction and a Measured Boundary in Online Conformal Prediction

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Abstract

1 Conformal PID states long-run coverage for an arbitrary bounded scorecaster, and
2 a published corollary extends it to any predictable perturbation of the deployed
3 threshold inside an admissible set; a contrary reading is in print, by the same
4 authors, and is acted on. We join the halves and claim neither. What we add is a
5 measurement outside that set: a one-scalar movement penalty on the *completed*
6 threshold forfeits Proposition 2’s rate by $42\times$ at $T = 10^6$ and, past a measurable
7 width, returns realised miscoverage 1.000000 against $\alpha = 0.1$ while the saturation
8 condition fires on every round. That width is $\tau^* = \sup r_t + \sup \hat{q}_t - b/2$, exactly
9 the corollary’s admissible radius at the null scorecaster—so the conceded result is
10 tight there, and leaving the set costs coverage rather than the rate. Under a legal
11 non-zero scorecaster, or Conformal PID’s own unbounded integrator, it does not.

12 1 Introduction

13 An online conformal method emits a threshold before each observation and moves it afterwards.
14 Where the interval feeds a decision carrying an incumbent state that movement is charged, and
15 forecast stability names it, scores it and prices it [Tunc et al., 2013, Godahewa et al., 2025, Van Belle
16 et al., 2023, Pritularga and Kourentzes, 2024, Genov et al., 2026, Van Belle et al., 2026]. Holding a
17 forecast’s level fixed and comparing what its temporal structure does was invented earlier, in forecast
18 verification, where the predictive marginal is matched on real producers and only the dependence
19 varies [Gneiting et al., 2007, Pinson and Girard, 2012, Worsnop et al., 2018]; that coverage and mean
20 length under-describe a deployed interval is established too [Min et al., 2026, Vaze, 2026]. None of it
21 is claimed here.

22 **The record contradicts itself, and the halves sit in different papers.** Conformal PID [Angelopoulos
23 et al., 2023] adds a *scorecaster* $\hat{q}_{t+1}$ to a saturating error integrator and asks of it only that it
24 be predictable and lie in $[-b/2, b/2]$ — “any function of the past” (Theorem 1) — so a movement
25 penalty placed in that slot is already quantified over. Also in print, of the same method: “[s]ince using
26 a scorecaster (D-part) in C-PID breaks the theoretical coverage guarantee, we only use the quantile
27 tracker and error integrator” [Li and Rodríguez, 2024] — one sentence in the baselines paragraph
28 of that paper’s experiments, stated and acted on there, and refereed: it survives verbatim on printed
29 page 18443. The general statement is in print too, twice and with proof: Li et al. [2025, Corollary 2]
30 add an arbitrary predictable d_t with $|d_t| \leq \mu_t(b/2 - |\hat{q}_t|)$ to the deployed threshold, observe that the
31 result “has exactly the CPID error-integration form”, and conclude $|E_T| \leq c h(T) + 1 = o(T)$; the
32 same generic-slot argument carries AcMCP’s long-run coverage [Wang and Hyndman, 2024]. The
33 first and last authors of Li et al. [2025] are the authors of Li and Rodríguez [2024] and cite it, so
34 the halves already share a bibliography; this is ordinary self-correction. What is useful is that four
35 surfaces — arXiv full text and abstracts, OpenReview, and the six works Semantic Scholar records
36 as citing it — return zero works printing both. A refereed 2026 paper separately calls the choice of

scorecaster model “arbitrary” and lacking “principled guidance” [Hu et al., 2026] while asserting valid coverage itself: a complaint about model selection and variance, not about validity. **We claim neither the placement nor the derivation.**

What that leaves open is the outside of the admissible set. Corollary 2 is a *retention* result: perturbations within $\mu_t(b/2 - |\hat{q}_t|)$ keep $|E_T| \leq c h(T) + 1$. The modification a stability-motivated designer reaches for leaves that set — a smoother on the *completed* output. Section 3 measures what that costs and where it becomes a coverage failure.

2 Setup

The producer. At time t a forecaster fit on data before t induces a score s_t , a threshold q_t is emitted before y_t is revealed, the deployed set is $C_t = \{y : s_t(x_t, y) \leq q_t\}$ and $\text{err}_t = \mathbf{1}\{s_t(x_t, y_t) > q_t\}$; the target is long-run coverage, $T^{-1} \sum_{t \leq T} \text{err}_t = \alpha + o(1)$, with no model on the data. Conformal PID [Angelopoulos et al., 2023] manipulates the threshold on the score scale,

$$q_{t+1} = \hat{q}_{t+1} + r_t \left(\sum_{i \leq t} (\text{err}_i - \alpha) \right), \quad (1)$$

their iteration (5), in which r_t saturates: condition (4) requires $r_t(x) \geq b$ for $x \geq c h(t)$ and $r_t(x) \leq -b$ for $x \leq -c h(t)$, with h nonnegative, nondecreasing, sublinear. Writing $E_t = \sum_{i \leq t} (\text{err}_i - \alpha)$, Proposition 2 gives $|E_T| \leq c h(T) + 1$, a coverage gap of at most $(c h(T) + 1)/T$; boundedness is read on realised scores.

One scalar, two readouts, two places to put it. A movement penalty on a sequentially updated scalar has two standard readouts, both prior work: a quadratic cost gives linear partial adjustment towards the target, $\tilde{q}_{t+1} = (1 - \lambda)\hat{q}_{t+1}^{\text{raw}} + \lambda\tilde{q}_t$ [Gârleanu and Pedersen, 2013], and a proportional cost a no-trade band, moving only when the target is more than τ away and then pulling back by exactly τ [Constantinides, 1986, Davis and Norman, 1990]. The first is what Godahewa et al. [2025] publish as post-processing and Binny and Dixit [2025, Eq. 13] apply to a deployed conformal threshold. It has two distinct positions in (1): **(B)** in the $\hat{q}_{t+1}$ slot, where both readouts keep $\{\hat{q}_t\}$ in the convex hull of $\hat{q}_1$ and the raw scorecaster’s range and so inside Corollary 2’s admissible set; and **(A)** downstream of the completed q_{t+1} , outside it. Placement A, what a designer reaches for because the deployed number is what has to sit still, is measured here.

The quantity, and the names it already has. We report the deployed threshold’s *travel*, $\mathcal{T}_H = \sum_{t=2}^H |q_t - q_{t-1}|$, after actuator travel in process control. The arithmetic is not new and the name is a convenience: $\sum |\Delta q|$ over a predictive distribution is the Multi-Quantile Change [Zanotti, 2026, v3, §3.4.1]; verification calls the same movement *jumpiness* [Zsótér et al., 2009], a *convergence index* [Ehret, 2010] and forecast *(in)consistency* [Pappenberger et al., 2011], all three imported by Van Belle et al. [2026]; applied control calls it IACER [Sarhadi, 2025]; and dynamic-regret online learning calls it a path length. Table 2’s caption names ten across four vocabularies: every natural name is taken, which is why a fresh one is used here, for one reading only.

Harness. $\alpha = 0.1$, $b = 2$, $c = 1$, $h(t) = \log(t + 2)$, and the clipped saturator $r_t(x) = b \text{clip}(x/(c h(t)), -1, 1)$, which meets condition (4) with equality. The scorecaster is null, legal and reducing (1) to the pure error integration Proposition 2 is stated about, so the readout is the only manipulated variable. Neither free choice is neutral — condition (4) is a lower bound and this saturator meets it exactly, and Theorem 1 permits scorecasters $b/2$ either side of the null one. The adversary is specified rather than tie-broken: it plays $s_t = \text{clip}(\tilde{q}_t + \varepsilon, \pm b/2)$, $\varepsilon = 10^{-9}$, against the *deployed* $\tilde{q}_t$ — the $\varepsilon \downarrow 0$ reading of “sets the score at the threshold”, firing the strict indicator. Legality is Theorem 1’s $[-b/2, b/2]$ on both sides, so $b/2 + b/2 = b$ is exactly tight.

3 The forfeit, measured

The rate is forfeited in the time constant that stability motivates raising. A downstream partial adjustment of weight w delays the correction the integrator has already computed. Its excursion at $T = 10^4$ is 6.30/63.00/623.70 for $w = 0.9/0.99/0.999$, and for the last two it is *flat in T* while

Table 1: Placement A: a one-scalar readout on the *completed* threshold; one deterministic adversary, one pass to $T = 10^6$, the i.i.d. control at one seed. Proposition 2’s bound is 13.2061 at $T = 2 \times 10^5$ and 14.8155 at $T = 10^6$; “ratio” is $\max_t |E_t|$ over it, “Sat.” the rounds on which (4) delivers its full $\pm b$.

Readout on the completed threshold	miscov. 2×10^5	$\max_t E_t \cdot 10^6$	ratio	Sat. 10^6	travel 10^6
none (control)	0.100035	7.80	0.53	0.0000	28,311
partial adj. $w = 0.9$	0.100030	7.50	0.51	0.0000	4,081
partial adj. $w = 0.99$	0.100040	63.00	4.25	0.0007	1,024
partial adj. $w = 0.999$	0.100035	623.70	42.10	0.0097	202
growing time constant $p = 0.9$	0.100030	53.00	3.58	0.3181	16
running mean	0.099940	49.50	3.34	0.3647	9
dead band $\tau = 0.5$	0.100035	10.60	0.72	0.0000	2,045
dead band $\tau = 0.9$	0.100060	13.20	0.89	0.0038	1,051
dead band $\tau = 1.5$	1.000000	900,000	60,747	1.0000	0.5

the bound grows like $\log T$, so the ratio falls with the horizon, 61.08 to 42.10; the measured law across the arms is $\max_t |E_t| \approx \max\{0.5 h(T) + 0.9, 0.63/(1 - w)\}$. Five of the nine exceed the bound at $T = 10^6$, so the forfeit is a property of the smoothing *strength* rather than of Placement A, and it buys something: the $w = 0.999$ arm cuts deployed travel from 28,311 to 202. The sign is the opposite of the intuitive one: a readout on the completed q_{t+1} touches neither r_t nor the integrator’s argument, so it cannot put condition (4) at risk; it delays the correction the integrator is waiting for, so the accumulator excurses *further*. Smoothing the output does not damp E_t , it feeds it. The 623.70 turns on the tie rule: an adversary playing the threshold *exactly* gives it with ties scored as misses and 70.80 under the strict indicator.

Coverage survives most of the time, and then it does not. Realised miscoverage at $T = 2 \times 10^5$ lies in 0.099940–0.100060 over the control and seven of the eight smoothed arms; the eighth loses coverage completely, and the width at which that happens is measurable. A dead band pulls the deployed threshold back by τ , so under saturation it is pinned τ below the integrator’s ceiling; measured, its realised supremum is $b - \tau$ to the printed digit at every $\tau \geq 0.9$. The adversary’s best legal play is $b/2$, so coverage is lost exactly when that supremum drops below it, at $\tau^* = \sup_x r_t(x) + \sup_t \hat{q}_t - b/2$; bands with $\tau \leq \tau^*$ cover. **The harness puts $\sup r_t = b$ and $\hat{q} \equiv 0$, so $\tau^* = b/2$ here** — one point of the admissible class, not a property of Placement A. Under the equally legal constant $\hat{q} \equiv +b/2$ the same $\tau = 1.5$ band covers at $T = 10^6$, miscoverage 0.100010 and $\max_t |E_t| = 11.20$, inside the bound; under $\hat{q} \equiv -b/2$, also legal, $\tau^* = 0$ and even $\tau = 0.5$ returns 1.000000. At $\hat{q} \equiv 0$ the transition is a step: $\tau = 1.000$ covers at $T = 10^5$ while $\tau = 1.001$ returns 1.000000. Past τ^* the threshold sits permanently below the reachable score range, the loop never closes and $|E_t| = (1 - \alpha)t$ grows linearly, 60,747 times the bound at $T = 10^6$; $\tau = 2.0, 2.5, 3.0$ and 5.0 fail too, so the failing set is (τ^*, ∞) , open at the left — the endpoint covers. **And the failing arms have Sat. = 1.0000**: the integrator delivers its full $\pm b$ on every round and the failure happens anyway. Condition (4) holds by construction; what fails is Proposition 2’s other hypothesis, that the threshold closing the loop *is* the integrator’s output.

What that measures is that the conceded result is tight. A dead band displaces the deployed threshold by exactly τ when it releases, so “inside Li et al.’s Corollary 2” reads $\tau \leq \mu_t(b/2 - |\hat{q}_t|)$, which at $\mu_t = 1, \hat{q}_t \equiv 0$ is the $b/2$ that τ^* returns. What is measured is therefore not a fresh boundary but that the published sufficient condition is *necessary* there, and that the price of leaving the set is coverage rather than the rate. Elsewhere it is only sufficient: at $\hat{q}_t \equiv +b/2$ Corollary 2 permits radius 0 while coverage survives to $\tau = b$.

4 Where this sits

Of the 862 references returned for Table 2’s twenty-six anchors, 13 fall in a neighbouring literature and twelve of those sit in three forecast-stability papers: Van Belle et al. [2026], co-authored by Pierre Pinson, cite eight works of verification, Genov et al. [2026] three of smoothed online optimisation, and Zanotti [2026] build their intervals out of conformal prediction. The edge exists where an author bridges it, and the cross-citation is concentrated rather than sparse. **We claim no disconnection**, and the counts above do not support one: the arXiv full-text index that returns zero for the switching-cost method names paired with “conformal” over-matches phrases, so its zeros are conservative and its

Table 2: Four literatures name the movement of a sequentially updated forecast in four vocabularies: *abrupt threshold changes*; *forecast (in)stability* (MASC, MAC/SDC, MQC/SMQC, congruence, nervousness); *jumpiness, convergence index, (in)consistency*; and *switching cost*. Cross-citation from Semantic Scholar reference lists, 20 August 2026, over that column’s anchors.

	Online conformal	Forecast stability	Verification	Switching-cost OL
Has that the others lack	a distribution-free long-run coverage guarantee for <i>any</i> bounded scorecaster, with a rate [Angelopoulos et al., 2023, Thm 1, Prop. 2]—and an admissible set measured here to be tight	the scored movement functional, the readout map as post-processing [Godaheva et al., 2025, Eq. 3], and a priced decision [Genov et al., 2026, §4.2], [Van Belle et al., 2026]	the matched-level design on real producers from 2012, with a control <i>stronger</i> than the pair: the whole marginal [Pinson and Girard, 2012, Worsnop et al., 2018]	worst-case theory for the pe-nalised problem: Thm 2, and a Thm 7 trade-off in which sublin-ear regret is bought by growing θ with T , which grows the ratio [Andrew et al., 2013]
Lacks that the others have	a calendar-time path functional and a decision charged to <i>move</i> rather than to violate; its metric is “zero for deterministic meth-ods by design” [Min et al., 2026, §4]	a coverage object in its canon-ical works: <i>conformal, cover-age, prediction interval</i> occur 0 times in Godahewa et al. [2025], Genov et al. [2026], Van Belle et al. [2026]; Zanotti [2026] ex-pected	a decision that pays to move— commissioned and declined [Pinson and Girard, 2012]—and the quantity itself: matched marginals fix the width path	any interval or coverage object; regret buys marginal coverage i.i.d. but not adversarially [Ra-malingam et al., 2025]
Cites the other three?	0/437, 1/437, 0/437; cites the shared OCO ancestor [Zinkevich, 2003]	1/226, 8/226, 3/226—all in three papers	0/106 in every direction avail-able	0/93 in every direction avail-able

positives are not counts, and an exact instrument refutes the reading they invite — of the 875 works citing Kalai and Vempala [2005], two are online conformal, Chen et al. [2023], cited here, and Zhang et al. [2024]. Four fields name one quantity many ways; the object that settles its validity sits in one.

What is conceded, by name. The placement is prior work: Angelopoulos et al. [2023] state coverage for any admissible integrator and any scorecaster and run a smoothing-family model in that slot themselves; Dupuy et al. [2026] give the generic argument in their Appendix A and Duerst et al. [2024] adopt that scorecaster. The derivation is prior work too, and that is the concession that matters most: Li et al.’s Corollary 2 proves the retention statement in Conformal PID’s own notation [Li et al., 2025], with Wang and Hyndman [2024] an independent second instance. The smoother object, the metric arithmetic and both readout maps are conceded in Section 2, and Zheng et al. [2025], Wu et al. [2025], Chen et al. [2023], Lade et al. [2026] each place a smoother inside their own validity argument. One vocabulary out, this is integrator anti-windup with a feedforward path, where free-until-the-bound-binds is the defining specification rather than a finding [Galeani et al., 2009]. Nearest in the other direction, Gao et al. [2025] run the same recursion but gate the *model* update on the conformal score; their one non-standard assumption is that $\sum_{t \leq T} q_t \leq O(\alpha h(T))$ for a sublinear h , supported with a plot and left to later work to derive. That accumulation is what Section 3 measures diverging.

5 Limitations

One construction, one adversary, one saturator — and its level is the operative choice. $0.63/(1 - w)$ is specific to that level, not to the saturator’s shape: raising the level to $4b$ — admissible, since (4) is a lower bound — cuts 623.70 to 120.60, and under the unbounded tangent integrator Angelopoulos et al. [2023] use in all their own experiments no width tried loses coverage, $\tau = 1.5$ covering at 0.100001 and 623.70 falling to 20.10. Both results are about *bounded* admissible integrators, which is what (4) permits and not what its authors run. **The inherited guarantee is weak where it applies.** With that integrator, $h(t) = t/\log t$ and their Appendix C constants (K_I at the score bound), the bound decays as $O(1/\log T)$: at $T = 2500$, our horizon, it certifies coverage only into $[0.821, 0.979]$ against 0.90. What is forfeited was not a tight certificate. **The dead-band widths are absolute, and the failure is total only against the adversary.** τ is in score units with $b = 2$, so the failing $\tau = 1.5$ is $0.75b$; under i.i.d. scores that arm returns 0.249376, under the tangent 0.100025. What survives is the mechanism: a band wider than τ^* caps the reachable threshold below the reachable score range. **The harness was rebuilt against numbers already read**, which carries less evidential weight than a blind rerun; the free choices are registered in the code and travel with every output. **Seven of the twenty-six anchors return an empty reference list**, so Table 2’s counts are gaps rather than zeros. **No downstream readout here recovers the bound.**

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